

When Do Political Opportunities Matter? Elite Ethnic Composition and Dissident Tactical Choice in Civil Conflicts

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Abstract

Why do some dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics while others turn to violence? Building on political opportunity theory, we argue that ethnic fragmentation within ruling elites and cross-ethnic power-sharing increase the attractiveness of nonviolent campaigns by enabling elite defections and constraining regime repression. Together, these mechanisms should enhance the expected effectiveness of nonviolent mobilization relative to violent alternatives. We test this argument using random-effects logistic regression models to assess whether elite ethnic fragmentation predicts dissident tactical choice. The results reveal little systematic relationship between elite fragmentation or power-sharing and the likelihood that dissidents choose nonviolent over violent strategies. Overall, the findings suggest that while ethnic fragmentation within ruling elites may matter for regime stability and campaign outcomes, it does not systematically shape dissidents' initial choice of tactics, challenging expectations derived from political opportunity theory.

Introduction

Why do some dissidents pursue their political objectives through nonviolent campaigns while others resort to violence? One important strand of literature looks at ethnicity. Many campaigns unfold along ethnic lines (Thurber 2018). Existing research focuses primarily on the ethnic characteristics of dissidents and the populations from which they mobilize. Yet ethnic conflicts involve actors on both sides of the line.

This paper contributes to the literature by shifting attention from the ethnic characteristics of dissidents to the ethnic composition of the ruling elites. Specifically we argue that ethnic fragmentation within ruling coalitions shapes dissidents' strategic choice between violent and nonviolent tactics. Drawing on political opportunity theory, we contend that campaign leaders select tactics based on their expected likelihood of success. Nonviolent campaigns are most attractive when dissidents anticipate elite defections and believe that repression will be limited or ineffective. Ethnically fragmented ruling elites create precisely these conditions. Fragmentation weakens coordination within the ruling coalition, increasing the likelihood that political and security elites defect during periods of mass mobilization. At the same time, ethnic divisions reduce the coherence and effectiveness of state repression by complicating both decision-making and implementation. As a result, ethnic fragmentation increases the expected benefits and reduces the expected costs of nonviolent mobilization relative to violent alternatives.

The argument further extends to the distribution of power within ruling coalitions: where power is shared more evenly among ethnic groups, coordination becomes more difficult and repression less cohesive, further increasing the attractiveness of nonviolent campaigns. The

paper therefore expects dissident campaigns operating under more ethnically fragmented and power-sharing ruling coalitions to be more likely to adopt nonviolent rather than violent tactics.

This argument speaks to a broader question in the study of political conflict. Research on campaign tactics emphasizes the importance of elite defections and repression, yet we know less about the factors that shape these processes. By examining the ethnic composition of ruling elites, this paper evaluates whether a central feature of ethnic power relations influences the strategic environment facing dissidents. In doing so, it connects research on ethnic politics to theories of campaign tactic choice.

To evaluate this argument, we combine data on maximalist dissident campaigns from the NAVCO 2.1 dataset with measures of ethnic power relations from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) project. Using random effects logistic regression models, we examine whether variation in the ethnic structure of ruling elites predicts campaign tactic choice. Contrary to theoretical expectations, the results provide little evidence that ethnic fragmentation or the distribution of power among ruling ethnic groups systematically influences whether dissidents adopt violent or nonviolent tactics. These null findings remain robust across several alternative specifications and subsamples.

The findings contribute to the literature on campaign tactics by suggesting that factors associated with elite defections and repression do not necessarily translate into differences in dissidents' initial tactical choices. They also contribute to the literature on ethnic politics by indicating that ethnic power structures may be more important for explaining conflict dynamics and outcomes than for explaining whether dissidents choose violent or nonviolent forms of contention.

Ethnicity and Campaign Tactic Choice

A campaign is a sustained collective effort to achieve a political objective, such as regime change, democratization, or territorial self-determination. Campaigns differ in the tactics they employ. Nonviolent campaigns rely on methods such as protests, strikes, boycotts, and sit-ins. Violent campaigns rely on armed force, including guerrilla warfare, insurgency, and terrorism.

Research has long argued that ethnicity shapes campaign tactics. Existing explanations generally focus on the ethnic characteristics of dissidents, campaigns, or populations. One line of research emphasizes political exclusion, showing that excluded ethnic groups are more likely to engage in violent conflict than politically included groups (Cederman, Wimmer, and Min 2010; Pischedda 2020). A second line of research examines the ethnic composition of campaigns and societies, arguing that ethnic structures influence the effectiveness of violent and nonviolent resistance (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Thurber 2018; Manekin and Mitts 2022).

Despite their differences, these explanations focus on characteristics of challengers rather than incumbents. Much less attention has been devoted to the ethnic composition of ruling elites.

Political Opportunities Shape Campaign Tactic Choice

To understand how the ethnic composition of ruling elites may influence campaign tactics, it is first necessary to explain how dissident organizations choose between violent and nonviolent resistance. Previous literature has shown that the choice between a violent or nonviolent

campaign is a strategic decision made before a campaign begins (Schock 2005; Cunningham 2013; Cunningham, Dahl, and Frugé 2017). The underlying assumption is that dissidents select the tactic they expect offers the greatest likelihood of achieving their political objectives. Political opportunity theory explains this choice by emphasizing how opportunities and constraints in the political environment shape the expected success of alternative strategies (Carey 2009; Young and Dugan 2011; Chenoweth and Ulfelder 2017). Campaign leaders weigh how the political environment shifts the likelihood of success of each campaign type.

The effectiveness of these campaigns depends on several political opportunities that shape their prospects for success. Two opportunities are particularly important: the potential to induce defections among regime supporters and the ability to sustain broad-based participation in the face of state repression.

The first opportunity stems from the central role that elite and security-force defections play in the success of nonviolent resistance. Nonviolent campaigns rely on their ability to induce defections among regime supporters (Cunningham, Dahl, and Frugé 2017; Arendt 1970; Sharp 1973; Nepstad 2011; Schock 2005; Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Chenoweth, Perkoski, and Kang 2017). Nonviolent mobilization can weaken regime stability by creating uncertainty about the regime's future survival and exposing divisions within the ruling coalition. As elites, bureaucrats and security personnel withdraw their support or refuse orders to repress dissent, the regime loses administrative and coercive capacity, making it increasingly difficult to maintain political control (Nepstad 2011; Chenoweth, Perkoski, and Kang 2017). Nonviolent resistance is therefore more likely to be attractive when dissidents expect elite and security-force loyalties to be fragile rather than cohesive.

Second, nonviolent campaigns depend on their ability to mobilize broad segments of

society. Large-scale participation increases a campaign’s capacity to disrupt political and economic activity, demonstrate the breadth of opposition to the regime, and exert pressure on incumbents (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011; Schock 2005). Arrests, violence, and intimidation increase the costs of participation and can discourage individuals from joining collective action (Sullivan 2016). Repression may also disrupt organizational networks by targeting activists responsible for coordinating protests and maintaining participation (Sullivan 2016). As participation falls, so does the campaign’s power, making success less likely. Consequently, dissidents are less likely to select nonviolent tactics when they expect the state to respond with severe repression (Edwards and Arnon 2021).

Taken together, nonviolent campaigns are most attractive when dissidents expect mobilization to generate defections among regime supporters and when repression is unlikely to prevent sustained collective action. Under such circumstances, nonviolent tactics provide a credible pathway to achieving political objectives. When opportunities for defection are limited and repression is expected to be severe, the anticipated benefits of nonviolent resistance decline relative to its costs. Dissidents may therefore conclude that peaceful resistance is unlikely to succeed and instead turn to violent forms of contention (Schock 2005; Cunningham 2013; Edwards and Arnon 2021).

Ethnic Fragmentation Creates Political Opportunities for Nonviolent Resistance

The preceding discussion identified two political opportunities that are particularly important for the attractiveness of nonviolent resistance: the prospect of elite defections and the

state's capacity to sustain repression. The remaining question is what factors shape these opportunities. This study argues that one important source of variation lies in the ethnic composition of ruling elites. Ethnic fragmentation influences both the likelihood of elite defection and the effectiveness of repression, thereby shaping the expected success of nonviolent mobilization relative to violent alternatives.

Specifically, ethnic fragmentation influences whether dissident organizations choose violent or nonviolent tactics by shaping two political opportunities central to nonviolent resistance: the likelihood of elite defections and the state's capacity to repress collective action. By increasing the prospects for elite defection and limiting the effectiveness of repression, ethnic fragmentation raises the expected benefits and lowers the expected costs of nonviolent mobilization.

Ethnic fragmentation increases the likelihood of elite defection by weakening coordination within the ruling coalition. When elites are organized into distinct ethnic blocs, their ability to jointly sustain loyalty to the regime becomes more fragile because political behavior is structured through segmented networks rather than a unified elite (Cederman, Wimmer, and Min 2010). This reduces the ability of incumbents to generate credible commitments about mutual support and increases uncertainty about how other elites will behave in moments of political stress. As a result, elites face a coordination problem: even those who might prefer regime continuity cannot be confident that others will remain loyal, making defection a safer individual strategy when political conditions begin to shift (Svolik 2012; Roessler 2011; Geddes 1999).

This coordination problem becomes especially consequential under conditions of political contestation, such as during nonviolent mobilization. Large-scale protest signals regime

vulnerability and creates uncertainty about the regime’s future stability. In ethnically fragmented coalitions, these signals are harder to interpret and coordinate around, because elites lack strong cross-bloc trust and shared expectations about collective action (Brubaker and Laitin 1998). As a result, even limited signs of wavering support can trigger anticipatory or sequential defection, as elites seek to avoid being left in an increasingly unstable coalition. Ethnic fragmentation therefore increases the probability that nonviolent campaigns will generate elite defections by amplifying uncertainty and undermining coordinated loyalty responses within the ruling elite (Cederman, Wimmer, and Min 2010; Svobik 2012; Roessler 2011).

Ethnic fragmentation also reduces the expected effectiveness of state repression by increasing the political risks associated with its use. Authorizing violent repression can exacerbate divisions within ruling coalitions because coercive actions may raise the perceived costs of continued loyalty for some elites. This dynamic increases the likelihood of intra-elite disagreement over repression and can generate additional defections among political and security elites. Anticipating these risks, leaders in fragmented coalitions may be more hesitant to rely on severe repression as a strategy of control (Svobik 2012; Roessler 2011).

These constraints extend into the implementation of repression itself. Where military and police institutions are divided along ethnic lines, coercive capacity becomes fragmented, making it more difficult to ensure consistent compliance with orders (Hendrix and Salehyan 2019). Ethnic divisions within the security apparatus can weaken command-and-control, reduce willingness to carry out repression against certain groups, and increase opportunities for selective noncompliance or hesitation. As a result, even when repression is authorized, its execution is likely to be less coordinated and less effective than in regimes characterized by

more cohesive coercive institutions (Cederman, Wimmer, and Min 2010; Roessler 2011).

Taken together, ethnic fragmentation creates a political environment in which nonviolent resistance becomes a more attractive strategic option. Greater opportunities for elite defection increase the likelihood that nonviolent mobilization can undermine regime support, while constraints on repression reduce the costs of sustained participation. Because both mechanisms improve the expected prospects for success of nonviolent campaigns relative to violent alternatives, dissident organizations operating in more ethnically fragmented regimes should be more likely to adopt nonviolent tactics.

Hypothesis 1. *Greater ethnic fragmentation in ruling elites increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics rather than violent tactics.*

While ethnic fragmentation captures the number of ethnic groups represented within the ruling coalition, coalition cohesion also depends on how power is distributed among those groups. Fragmented coalitions are not necessarily unstable if one group clearly dominates decision-making and possesses the capacity to discipline potential challengers (Svolik 2012). Conversely, when power is distributed more evenly across ethnic groups, individual blocs possess greater autonomy and bargaining leverage, making coordinated loyalty more difficult to sustain (Roessler 2011; Wimmer, Cederman, and Min 2009). One great power is also capable of pushing through a unified repression strategy. Power sharing therefore represents a second dimension of elite fragmentation that may further increase opportunities for elite defection and constrain effective repression.

More equal distributions of power create a coalition of mutual veto players whose cooperation is necessary for regime stability. Because no single group can reliably impose

its preferences on others, coalition maintenance depends on continuous bargaining among actors with comparable resources and independent support bases (Svolik 2012; Gandhi and Przeworski 2007). These conditions increase the risk of elite defection during periods of political uncertainty and make the implementation of repression more difficult to coordinate (Roessler 2011). As a result, nonviolent mobilization should be particularly attractive in regimes characterized by extensive power sharing.

Hypothesis 2. *Power sharing among ethnic groups in the ruling elite increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics rather than violent tactics.*

Data and Methods

Data description

We test our hypotheses using the NAVCO 2.1 dataset, which documents 384 maximalist anti-government campaigns from 1945 to 2013 (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011). The unit of analysis is the campaign onset, as our theory concerns the initial choice between violent and nonviolent resistance. Following NAVCO coding protocols, campaigns are categorized by their main tactic into two mutually exclusive groups: violent and nonviolent. We operationalize this distinction as a binary variable (1 = violent, 0 = nonviolent). Our final sample includes 185 violent and 156 nonviolent campaign onsets¹.

¹The most significant reason why the number of campaigns we have in the panel dataset differs from the total number of maximalist campaigns concerns country coding. We construct a panel dataset of independent country-years based on Correlates of War (CoW) list of independent states. We merge our panel data using NAVCO-assigned CoW country codes. However, in some cases, countries of a campaign location are not independent at the campaign onset year and thus lost from the data we use in the analysis. For example, there is a campaign geographically located in Algeria in 1952, though Algeria gained independence only in 1962. A naive solution would be assigning socio-economic characteristics of the “target” country - France in case of Algeria, though it would severely bias the results as if the campaign took place in France. We partly

Our key independent variables come from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) Core Dataset (Vogt et al. 2015), which records politically relevant ethnic groups and their access to state power.

For Hypothesis 1, we follow Hendrix and Salehyan (2019) and measure ethnic elite fragmentation using the Included Fractionalization Index (IFI):

$$IFI = 1 - \sum_{i=1}^N s_i^2$$

where s_i is the population share of included ethnic group (i)². IFI captures the fragmentation of the ruling coalition. Unlike a simple count of included groups, it also accounts for their relative size. Higher values indicate more fragmented ruling coalitions, while lower values indicate that executive power is concentrated among fewer ethnic groups.

For Hypothesis 2, we use a binary indicator derived from the highest EPR access-to-power category to distinguish between concentrated and shared executive power (Vogt et al. 2015; Hlatky and Landry 2025). For each campaign, the variable is coded as 1 if the highest status held by any politically relevant ethnic group is Senior Partner, indicating a meaningful power-sharing arrangement where executive authority is shared among multiple groups. It is coded as 0 if the highest status is Monopoly (exclusive control by a single group) or Dominant (one group controls the executive while others hold subordinate positions).

To reduce confounding, we control for standard economic, demographic, and political factors that may be correlated with both ethnic elite structures and campaign tactics. Economic

address this issue by excluding territorial campaigns in the robustness check section. Table F.1 in Appendix C lists all these lost campaigns.

²EFI follows an analogous construction, where s_i would be the population share of excluded ethnic groups.

controls include GDP per capita, GDP growth, and logged population size. Demographic controls include youth bulge, measured as the share of the population aged 15–29. Political controls include executive corruption, electoral democracy (polyarchy), regime duration, and peace years since the last maximalist campaign (Gapminder 2024; Nations 2024; Coppedge et al. 2024).

We also include excluded ethnic fractionalization (EFI), constructed analogously to IFI but using the population shares of excluded ethnic groups rather than included groups (Hendrix and Salehyan 2019). This controls for ethnic heterogeneity among excluded populations, ensuring that effects attributed to ruling coalition fragmentation are not confounded by broader ethnic structure. Finally, we control for whether a campaign is initiated by an included ethnic group to ensure that results are not driven by systematic differences between campaigns initiated by included versus excluded groups.

Our theory focuses on pre-onset strategic decisions about campaign tactics. We therefore use lagged values of all independent variables from the previous year to capture the political environment in which these decisions are made.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for all variables, separately for violent and nonviolent campaigns. In the raw means, violent campaigns exhibit slightly higher levels of ethnic elite fragmentation (IFI) and more inclusive ethnic power-sharing arrangements within the executive compared to nonviolent campaigns.

Missing data is limited and does not pose a systematic concern for the analysis. In total, only 7.33% of IFI values and 13.2% of EPR highest access-to-power observations are missing.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Campaign Tactics (NAVCO 2.1 Onsets)

	Nonviolent (N=156)		Violent (N=185)	
	Mean	Std. Dev.	Mean	Std. Dev.
Main Variables				
Included Fractionalization Index	0.60	0.32	0.71	0.29
Executive Power Sharing	0.35	0.48	0.48	0.50
Control Variables				
Excluded Fractionalization Index	0.95	0.12	0.92	0.16
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	0.08	0.28	0.09	0.29
ln(GDP per capita)	8.66	0.89	7.98	0.94
ln(Population)	9.75	1.69	9.81	1.57
Polyarchy	0.30	0.18	0.26	0.17
Executive Corruption	0.61	0.24	0.63	0.25
ln(Regime Duration)	2.25	1.25	1.72	1.25
Peace Years	15.46	14.90	9.79	10.96

Note: All variables are one-year lagged. Included Fractionalization Index (IFI): Higher values indicate greater fragmentation among included ethnic groups. Executive Power Sharing (binary): 1 = shared executive authority among ethnic groups, 0 = indicate concentrated executive control.

Modeling approach

Because the dependent variable captures whether a campaign onset is violent or nonviolent, we estimate logistic regression models. The focus of the analysis is on the choice of tactic at campaign onset, rather than the timing or duration of campaigns; a binary logit specification is therefore appropriate. As we do not predict the duration of events, there is no need for advanced binary choice models such as a complementary log-log.

To account for the panel structure of the data - where multiple campaign onsets may occur within the same country - we include country-level varying intercepts. This allows baseline differences in the propensity toward violent versus nonviolent campaign onset to vary across countries.

Including a country fixed effect to control for the time-invariant unobserved factors such

as culture or geography is theoretically appealing and common in the peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016; Ives and Breslawski 2022; Fearon and Laitin 2003; Jung 2025). Ethnic configurations change slowly over time, and exploratory analysis indicates limited within-country variation in both IFI and EFI. As a result, a fixed-effects specification would rely primarily on the relatively small subset of countries that experience meaningful changes in ethnic inclusion structures across campaign onsets. Given that our theoretical argument concerns how both cross-national differences and temporal variation in elite ethnic structures shape strategic choices, we retain both sources of variation. A random-intercepts specification is therefore more consistent with the structure of the data and the substantive scope of the hypotheses.

We acknowledge, however, that random-effects models rely on a stronger assumption than fixed effects—namely that country-specific unobserved heterogeneity is uncorrelated with the included regressors. If this assumption is violated, coefficient estimates may be biased (Clark and Linzer 2015). Despite this limitation, the random-intercepts approach represents an appropriate trade-off between bias and efficiency in this setting, given the limited within-country variation in key predictors. To assess the sensitivity of our results to this assumption, we follow Bell and Jones (2015) and estimate an alternative Within-Between Random Effect (REWB) model specification as a robustness check.

For Hypothesis 1, our model specification is:

$$\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it})$$

$$\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1 - \pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{IFI})_{it-1} + \beta_2(\text{EFI})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_{[j]i}$$

$$\alpha_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\alpha, \sigma_\alpha^2)$$

where $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$ denotes the vector of lagged control variables and u_i is a country-specific random intercept capturing unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity.

For Hypothesis 2, our model specification is:

$$\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it})$$

$$\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1 - \pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Senior Partner})_{it-1} + \beta_2(\text{EFI})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_{[j]i}$$

$$\alpha_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\alpha, \sigma_\alpha^2)$$

where Senior Partner is a binary indicator of whether the highest status held by any politically relevant ethnic group is Senior Partner, $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$ denotes the vector of lagged control variables and u_i is a country-specific random intercept capturing unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity.

For uncertainty calculations, we follow a King’s simulation approach (King, Tomz, and Wittenberg 2000). This approach is also well-established in peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016). Instead of reporting coefficients and their significance, we calculate predicted probabilities as the main quantity of interest via an observed value approach (OVA), meaning we simulate the predicted probabilities for all observations and then calculate the mean of them³. We simulate over the full available range of the vocal variable values. For

³We report coefficients only in the cross-validation robustness check.

the essay, we define `sim_ova_range` function for the OVA simulations, allowing to calculate predicted probabilities in just few lines of code. We also define a `sim_ova_fd` function, allowing to calculate simulated first differences. It also allows for different CI levels, seeds, number of values and focal variable ranges at the researcher's discretion.

Results

Hypothesis 1

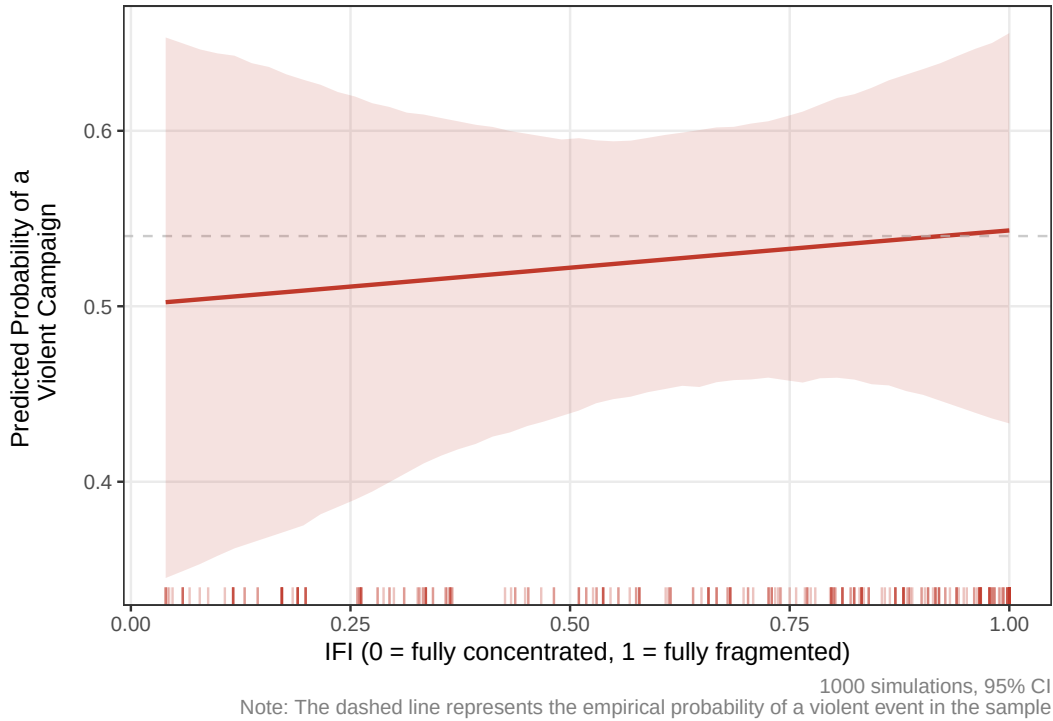


Figure 1: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of included fractionalization index values

To test the first hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H1 model specification⁴. Figure 1 shows the simulated predicted probabilities of a

⁴Regression coefficients are available in Table C.1 in Appendix C

violent tactic choice over a full available range of observed IFI values. Despite an upward trend - from 0.5 at IFI equal to 0.04 to 0.54 at IFI equal to 1 - confidence intervals that encompass 0.54, which is the empirical probability of a violent campaign, do not allow us to claim that with the increasing IFI the rebels would prefer violence over nonviolence.

Table 2: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 1

	Actual Nonviolent	Actual Violent
Confusion Matrix		
Predicted Nonviolent	21	7
Predicted Violent	15	31
Performance Metrics		
Accuracy	0.703	
Precision	0.674	
Recall	0.816	
F1 Score	0.738	
AUC	0.826	

Despite an insignificant effect of IFI on a violent choice, the model as a whole demonstrates a strong predictive performance. Model fit was evaluated using out-of-sample prediction. A train-test split mode reestimation was employed to calculate classification accuracy, precision, recall, F1 scores, and the area under the receiver operating characteristic curve (AUC). Table 2 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. With an accuracy of 0.7 and F1 score of 0.74, our model in general predicts tactic choice well above a coin toss, predicting violence a bit better than the nonviolent choice. Another measure of model fit is the area under the ROC curve (AUC), showing whether our model predictions of a violent choice are better than a random draw. The AUC score of 0.83 indicates a good model fit. Figure A.1 in Appendix A plots an AUC-ROC curve for this model. An important implication here is that the model as a whole (including the specification itself, a set of covariates and a country

varying intercept) captures meaningful variation in the outcome, even though the IFI does not significantly predict a violent choice. Such results reflect a real absence of the IFI effect rather than a model misspecification.

Hypothesis 2

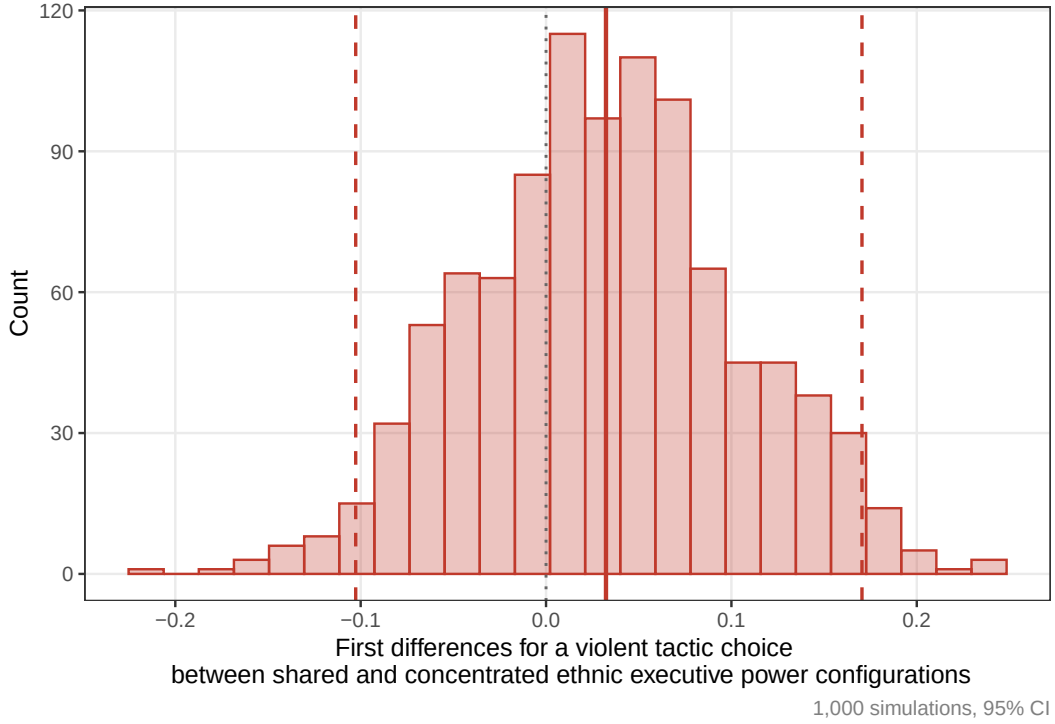


Figure 2: Simulated first differences for a violent tactic choice between shared and concentrated ethnic executive power

To test the second hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H2 model specification⁵. Given the binary independent variable, we calculated simulated first differences according to the observed value approach. Figure 2 shows the simulated first differences of a violent tactic choice between the shared (`epr_highest_rank`

⁵Initially, the model did not converge with the `bobyqa` optimizer. Following Bates et al. (2015), we reestimate the model with all the available optimizers. Then, we pick the model with the highest log-likelihood value among the converged models. As a result of such reestimation, we use the converged model for simulating first differences. Regression coefficients are available in Table C.1 in Appendix C.

= 1) and concentrated (`epr_highest_rank` = 0) ethnic executive power configurations. The results clearly indicate that, despite a positive mean value of the first differences, there are no systematic and statistically significant differences between the effects of shared and concentrated ethnic executive power on the violent tactic choice. It contrasts with theoretical expectations where ethnic power-sharing arrangements could push the dissidents towards one repertoire of contention over the other.

Table 3: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 2

	Actual Nonviolent	Actual Violent
Confusion Matrix		
Predicted Nonviolent	15	5
Predicted Violent	14	29
Performance Metrics		
Accuracy	0.698	
Precision	0.674	
Recall	0.853	
F1 Score	0.753	
AUC	0.796	

As well as with the model 1, we test the model fit using out-of-sample prediction. Table 3 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. All the metrics, especially F1 Score and AUC, indicate a good model fit as well. According to the confusion matrix, the model predicts violent tactic choice particularly successfully. Figure B.1 in Appendix B plots an AUC-ROC curve for this model. In general, both models successfully capture meaningful variation in the outcome.

Assumption Diagnostics

A series of diagnostic tests were conducted for the models of both hypotheses. Variance inflation factors indicated no evidence of multicollinearity among the explanatory variables. The assumption of linearity on the logit scale was assessed by comparing the baseline specifications to models including natural spline terms for the main explanatory variables. As the spline specifications did not improve model fit, the linear specifications were retained. Furthermore, DHARMA residual diagnostics, including quantile and QQ-plot assessments, revealed no substantial deviations from model expectations and provided no evidence of serious misspecification. Influence diagnostics based on Cook’s distance indicated that the results were not driven by a small number of influential observations. Detailed diagnostic results are reported in Appendix D (Tables D.1–D.4 and Figures D.1–D.4).

Robustness Checks

We conduct four robustness checks to assess the stability of the findings⁶. First, given that civil conflicts and a tactic choice are regionally clustered, we estimate an additional model on the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) and Sub-Saharan Africa countries subsample, where violent campaigns are more expected than in other regions. For the full sample, there are 54.3% of violent campaigns, whilst for MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa there are 65.5% of them. Second, following Bell and Jones (2015), we estimate an alternative Within-Between Random Effect (REWB) model specification. REWB presents a main independent variable in two forms: its demeaned form and a group mean. De-meaning allows to estimate a *within*

⁶An important note here is that we do not compare the model fit of these specifications because of the different samples, which make the models incomparable in terms of model fit measures.

(essentially fixed) effect and save the underlying assumption of the varying intercept model. Thirdly, simulation-based cross-validation was employed to assess the stability of coefficient estimates across repeated subsamples. Finally, for Hypothesis 1, we use an alternative operationalization of ethnic elite fragmentation via ethnic groups in power counts⁷. Across these alternative specifications and samples, the substantive conclusions remained unchanged, providing additional confidence in the robustness of the findings.

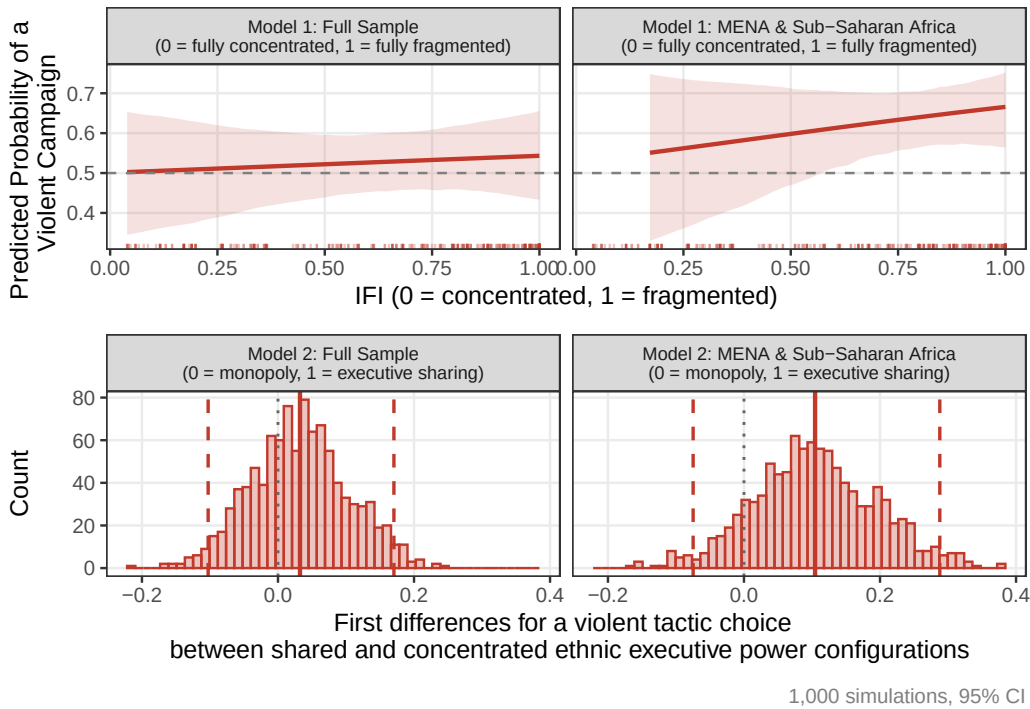


Figure 3: Simulated first differences for a violent tactic choice between shared and concentrated ethnic executive power

Figure 3 displays the results of regional subsampling robustness checks. For a Model 1 robustness check, the IFI coefficient remains insignificant, though the effect of the IFI on the violent choice is much stronger. The confidence intervals stay above the empirical probability of the violent choice across most of the IFI range, proving our assumption that in

⁷Despite rejecting ethnic groups counts as the main operationalization of ethnic elite fragmentation, such a measurement can also be found in the literature (Bivens and Thurber 2026)

specific regions the effect of the IFI is more pronounced and better identified. For a Model 2 robustness check, the mean first difference is slightly shifted rightward, though the confidence intervals cross zero as well as in the full sample, suggesting the robustness of the H2 findings.

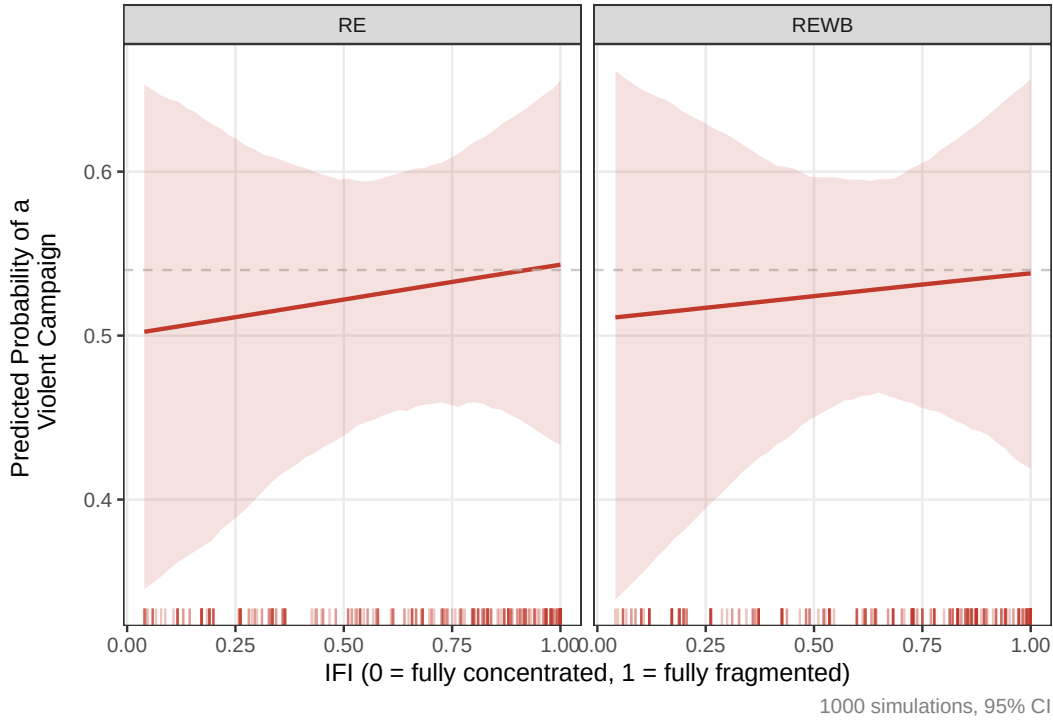


Figure 4: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of IFI values - baseline vs. REWB

Figure 4 plots the simulated predicted probabilities over the full range of IFI values for both RE and REWB models (Hypothesis 1). A slight upward trend with confidence intervals crossing the empirical probability of a violent tactic choice for both models suggests the robustness of the findings. You can find a first differences plot between RE and REWB models in Figure E.1 in Appendix E.

Table 4: Cross-Validation Comparison: Model 1 vs Model 2

Variable	Model 1		Model 2	
	Main	Cross-Validated	Main	Cross-Validated
IFI	0.194 (0.721)	0.377 (0.405)	NA	NA
Executive Power Sharing	NA	NA	0.175 (0.382)	0.277 (0.388)
EFI	-1.634 (1.582)	-1.623 (1.307)	-1.675 (1.405)	-2.771 (3.357)
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	-0.086 (0.529)	-0.782 (0.108)	-0.162 (0.510)	-0.803 (0.254)
ln(GDP per capita)	-0.951 (0.260)	-0.018 (0.391)	-0.775 (0.233)	-0.087 (0.766)
ln(Population)	-0.095 (0.138)	-0.085 (0.109)	-0.089 (0.126)	-0.098 (0.099)
Executive Corruption	0.159 (0.767)	-0.068 (0.414)	0.197 (0.719)	0.265 (0.917)
Polyarchy	0.573 (1.047)	0.236 (0.800)	0.382 (1.044)	0.863 (1.199)
ln(Regime Duration)	-0.293 (0.144)	-0.181 (0.122)	-0.289 (0.141)	-0.241 (0.160)
Peace Years	-0.020 (0.014)	-0.027 (0.013)	-0.018 (0.014)	-0.022 (0.016)

Note: Intercept is not reported. Standard errors in parentheses. Cross-validated SE via King (2001) combination rule.

We cross-validate the results (5 cross-validations) to check whether the same results hold when models are estimated on different random subsamples. For this, we define the `cross_validation_fun` function⁸. For this part, we did not calculate quantities of interest, but rather compare coefficient values and their significance, which will be enough to judge whether the results are stable or not. Table 4 shows the coefficients differences between the main and the cross-validated model. For both models, the IFI coefficient is negative and insignificant, though the coefficient absolute values differ. Moreover, one could notice a slight inflation of the standard errors, though not significantly changing the null result. Moreover, the reader should account for the sample size and respective test sample sizes that partly explain standard errors' inflation.

Finally, we reestimate the model with the count of ethnic groups in power (EGIP). EGIP encompasses groups that exercise political power either via maintaining ethnic dominance or through power-sharing arrangements with junior partners. We log the count, assuming a nonlinear effect on the violent tactic choice. Instead of EFI, we control for the logged count of marginalized ethnic groups - those that are politically excluded from decision making, including both powerless and purposely discriminated groups. Figure 5 plots the simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over the regular EGIP counts⁹. Similarly to the results with IFI, there is a slight insignificant upward trend. It once again shows the robustness of the results.

⁸Cross-validation subsampling causes convergence issues due to low sample sizes of the subsamples. To address this, we force the function to resample and reestimate the model until convergence. Thus, it can take more than one attempt to estimate one cross-validated subsample. It took 9 attempts for Model 1 and 10 for Model 2 to estimate 5 cross-validations

⁹We exponentiated the logged counts

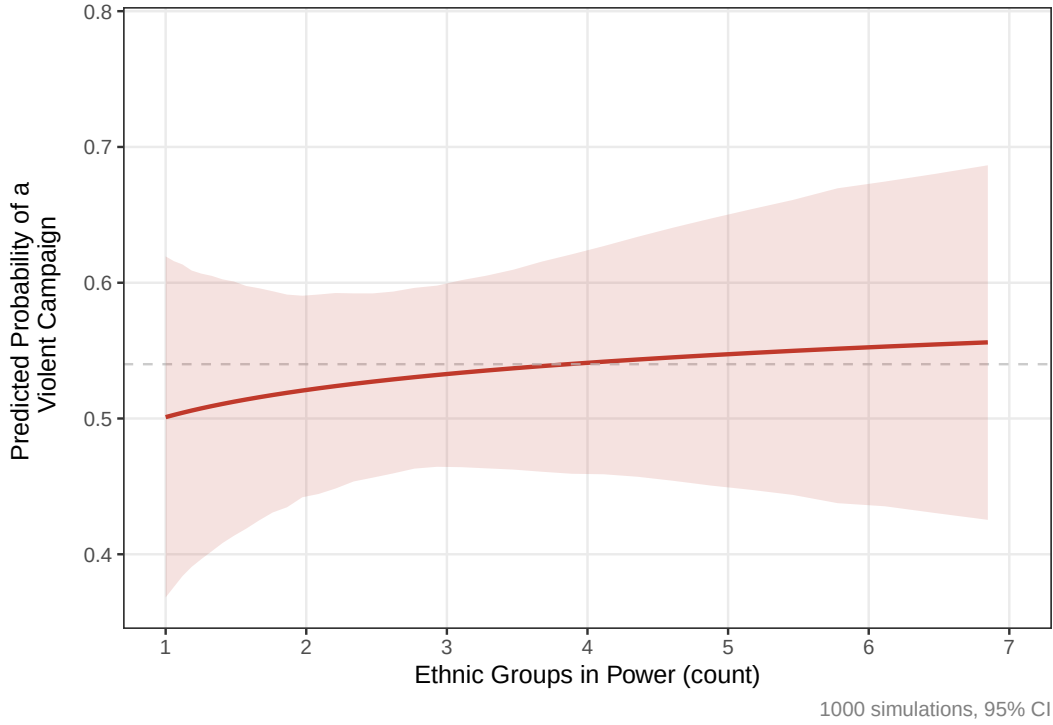


Figure 5: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over Ethnic Groups in Power counts

Discussion

Several theoretical and empirical limitations must be mentioned. First of all, this essay considered the repertoire of contention as a solely binary variable, assuming either a violent or a nonviolent tactic. Even though such a distinction is well-established in the literature, violent flank activity (when a minority of radicalized activists adopt a more violent resistance approach within a primarily nonviolent movement) should also be controlled for in future research. Moreover, campaign onsets themselves can be informationally insufficient. Violent flanks can occur over time and such dynamics of contention should also be addressed.

Secondly, the data structure shapes and constrains the research question. In our essay, we worked with a campaign onset dataset, assuming a campaign start as something endogenous. Maximalist campaign onsets are rare events, and refusing to start the campaign (“no onset”)

is also a strategic choice, which should also be modelled. It is possible in case of moving from campaign onset data structure to the country-year structure, allowing for observations without an onset. However, in this case, nonviolent and violent onsets are treated separately and independently, rather than two repertoire choices.

Finally, some methodological concerns should also be mentioned. We used a random effects model to exploit both within- and between-group variations. The RE approach was considered a reasonable compromise between pooling and fixed effects. However, the within-group variation is very close to zero, leading to mostly cross-sectional analysis of tactic choices. This means that time-invariant factors are only partly controlled. We approached this issue with an alternative Within-Between Random Effect estimations, though it is not an ideal methodological cure-all.

Conclusion

Why do some dissident movements choose violence while others pursue nonviolent resistance? This paper examined whether part of the answer lies in the ethnic composition of ruling elites. Building on political opportunity theories, we argued that ethnic fragmentation and a more equal distribution of power among ruling ethnic groups could weaken elite cohesion, increase the likelihood of defections, reduce the effectiveness of repression, and make concessions more likely. These conditions were expected to increase the attractiveness of nonviolent resistance relative to violent tactics.

Using data on maximalist campaigns from the NAVCO 2.1 project and measures of ethnic power relations from the EPR dataset, we tested whether ethnic elite composition influences

campaign tactic choice. The empirical results provide little support for this argument. Neither ethnic fragmentation among ruling elites nor the distribution of power across ruling ethnic groups consistently predicts whether dissidents adopt violent or nonviolent tactics. Moreover, these null findings remain robust across alternative model specifications and subsamples.

These findings are relevant because they challenge a plausible extension of political opportunity theory. Existing research suggests that elite defections, repression, and concessions are important determinants of campaign success and strategic choice. If ethnic fragmentation affects these mechanisms, one might expect it to shape campaign tactics as well. The results presented here suggest that this connection is weaker than anticipated. While ethnic divisions within ruling coalitions may influence regime stability, conflict dynamics, or campaign outcomes, they do not appear to systematically affect the initial choice between violent and nonviolent resistance.

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Appendix

Appendix A: AUC - ROC Curve - Model 1

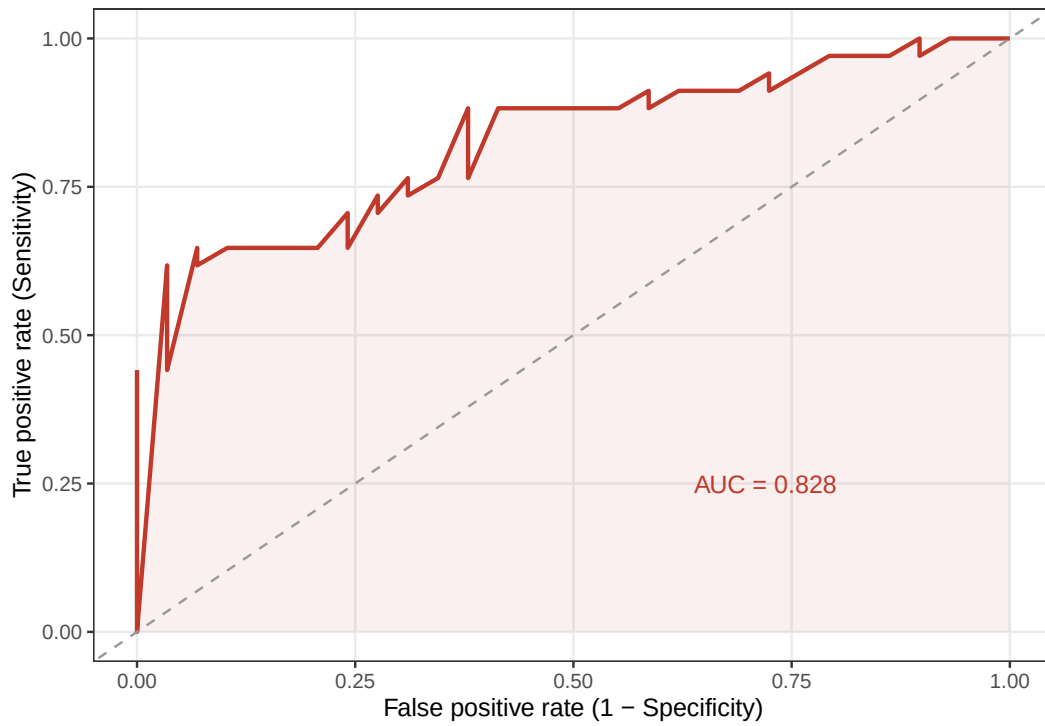


Figure A.1: AUC-ROC Curve - Model 1

Appendix B: AUC - ROC Curve - Model 2

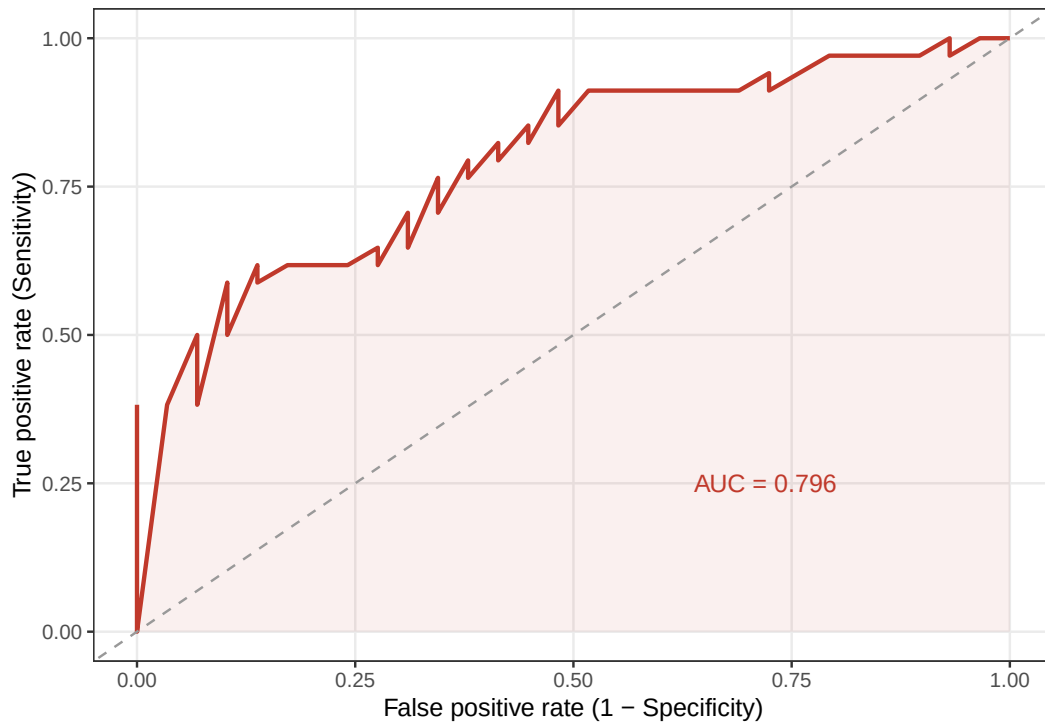


Figure B.1: AUC-ROC Curve - Model 2

Appendix C: Model 1 and 2 regression coefficients

Table C.1: Mixed-Effects Logistic Regression Models

	H1	H2
IFI	0.194 (0.721)	
Executive Power Sharing		0.175 (0.382)
EFI	-1.634 (1.582)	-1.675 (1.405)
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	-0.086 (0.529)	-0.162 (0.510)
ln(GDP per capita)	-0.951*** (0.260)	-0.775*** (0.233)
ln(Population)	-0.095 (0.138)	-0.089 (0.126)
Polyarchy	0.573 (1.047)	0.382 (1.044)
Executive Corruption	0.159 (0.767)	0.197 (0.719)
ln(Regime Duration)	-0.293* (0.144)	-0.289* (0.141)
Peace Years	-0.020 (0.014)	-0.018 (0.014)
Num.Obs.	297	266

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Country random intercepts are included in all models.

Appendix D: Assumptions diagnostics

Table D.1: Variance Inflation Factors

Variable	H1	H2
Main Variables		
IFI	1.38	NA
Executive Power Sharing	NA	1.21
Control Variables		
EFI	1.24	1.15
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	1.10	1.13
ln(GDP per capita)	1.25	1.24
ln(Population)	1.17	1.14
Polyarchy	1.26	1.27
Executive Corruption	1.13	1.08
ln(Regime Duration)	1.22	1.20
Peace Years	1.35	1.35

Note: Variance Inflation Factors (VIFs) assess multicollinearity among predictors. Values close to 1 indicate negligible multicollinearity.

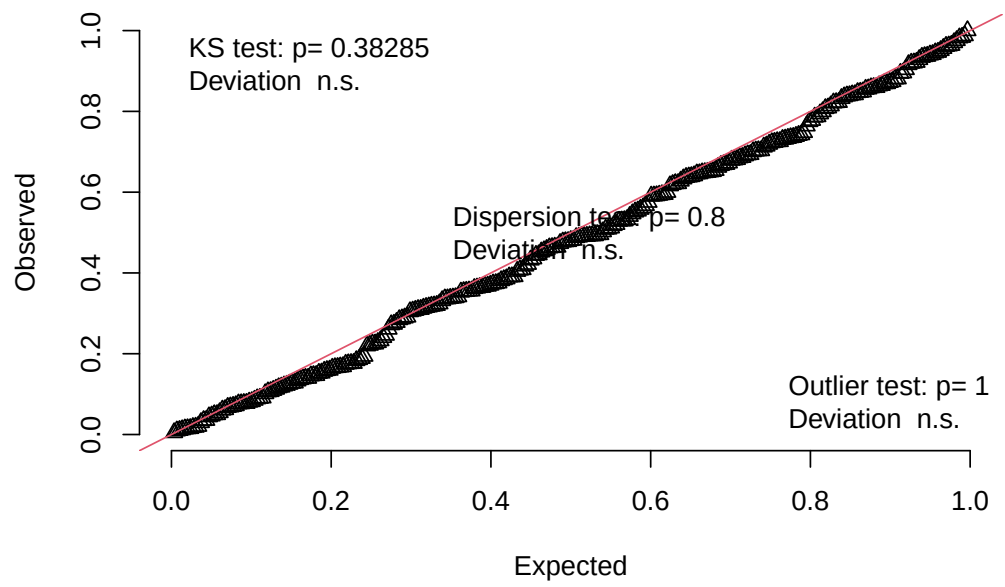


Figure D.1: Residual QQ plots (Model 1)

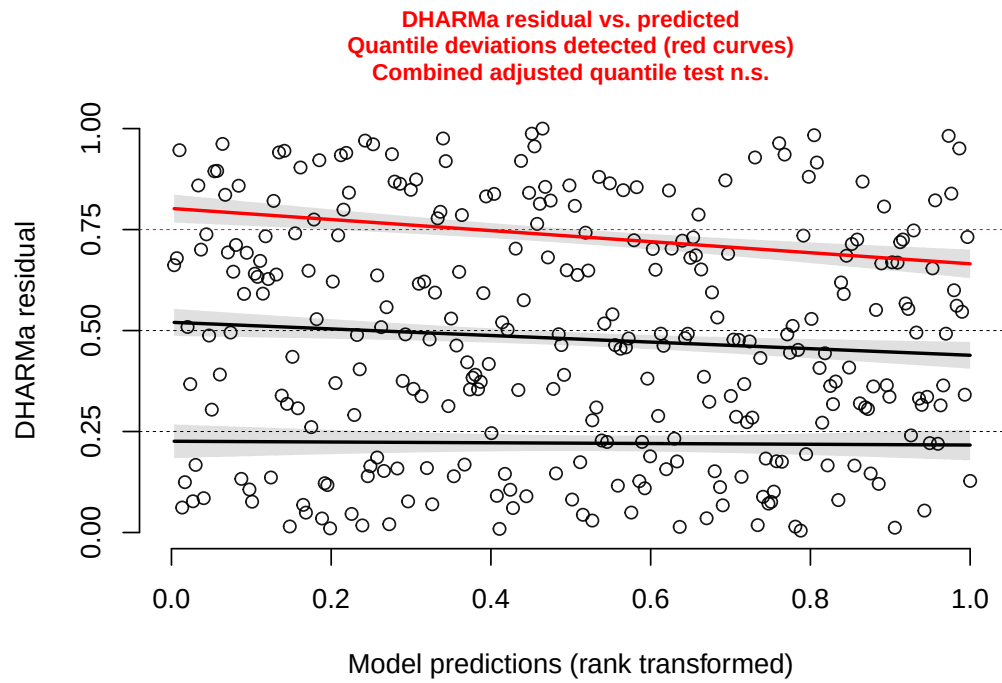


Figure D.2: DHARMa residual diagnostics (Model 1)

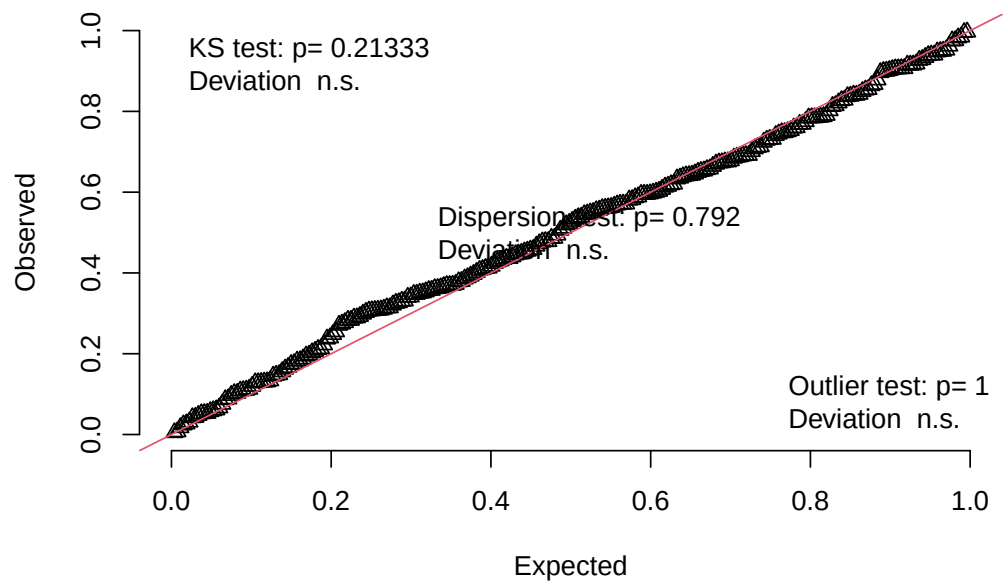


Figure D.3: Residual QQ plots (Model 2)

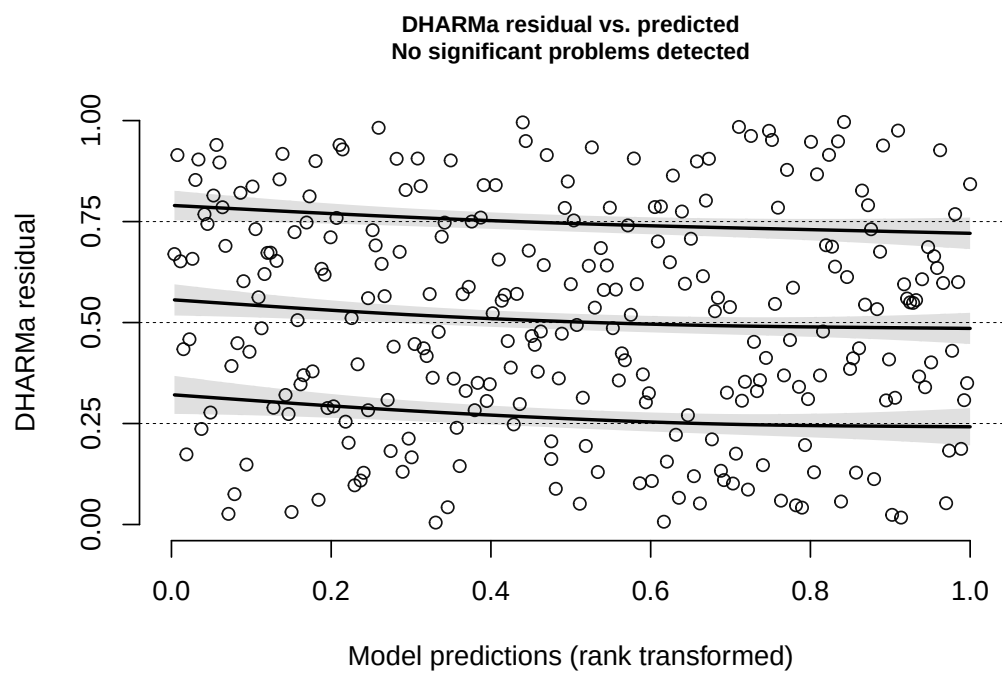


Figure D.4: DHARMa residual diagnostics (Model 2)

Table D.2: Logistic Models without Influential Outliers

	H1	H2
IFI	0.422 (1.032)	
Executive Power Sharing		0.530 (0.512)
EFI	-3.888 (2.735)	-4.500 (2.470)
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	0.074 (0.667)	0.157 (0.635)
ln(GDP per capita)	-1.543*** (0.384)	-1.324*** (0.366)
ln(Population)	-0.207 (0.201)	-0.219 (0.189)
Polyarchy	-0.062 (1.431)	0.653 (1.425)
Executive Corruption	0.775 (1.085)	0.554 (1.008)
ln(Regime Duration)	-0.611** (0.205)	-0.651** (0.210)
Peace Years	-0.038 (0.020)	-0.027 (0.020)
Num.Obs.	280	250

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note: Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Country random intercepts are included in all models.

Table D.3: Comparison of Baseline and Spline Specifications

Model	AIC	BIC	LogLik
Hypothesis 1			
H1 Baseline	368.6	409.2	-173.3
H1 Splines	371.4	426.8	-170.7
Hypothesis 2			
H2 Baseline	341.2	380.6	-159.6
H2 Splines	342.2	388.8	-158.1

Note: Spline models replace the focal explanatory variable with a natural spline specification ($df = 3$). Higher-order spline coefficients are omitted because they lack substantive interpretation. Model fit is evaluated using AIC and BIC.

Table D.4: Country-Level Random Intercept Variance

Statistic		H1	H2
(Intercept)	Country Intercept Variance	1.344	0.763
	Country Intercept SD	1.160	0.874

Note: Reported values are estimates of the country-level random intercept variance and standard deviation. Non-zero variance indicates meaningful between-country heterogeneity.

Appendix E: First Differences plot: RE and REWB models (Hypothesis 2)

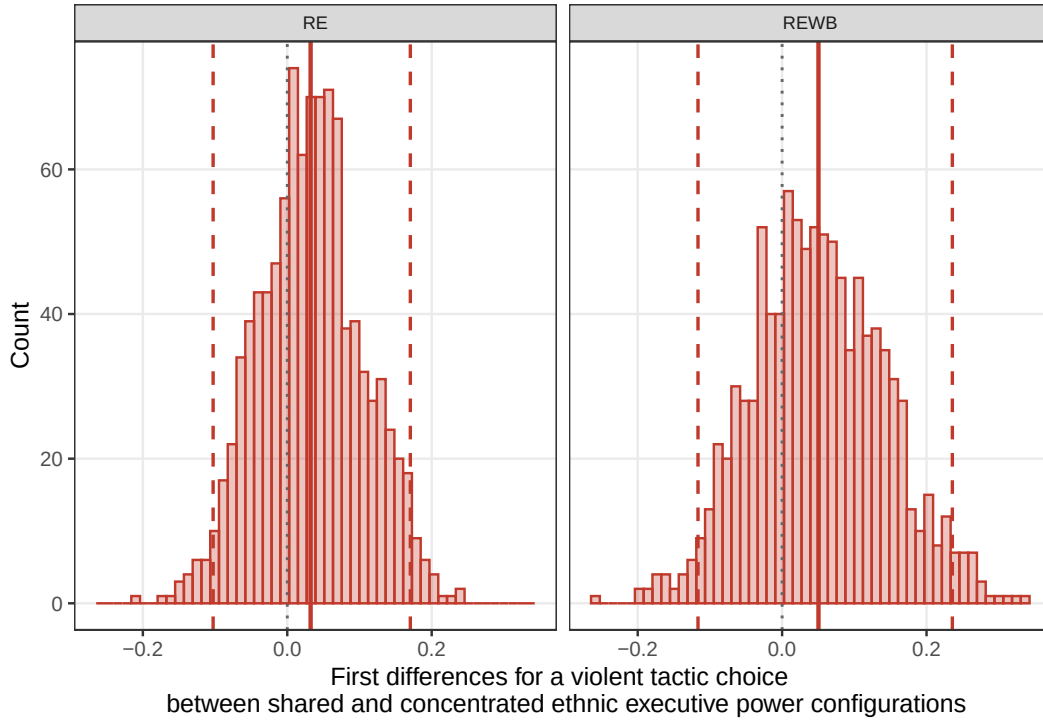


Figure E.1: First differences for a violent tactic choice between shared and concentrated ethnic executive power configurations - baseline vs. REWB

Appendix F: Campaigns excluded from the empirical analysis due to country coding issues

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample due to states panel coverage

COW code	Year	Country
615	1952	Algeria
540	1961	Angola
370	1988	Belarus
346	1991	Bosnia & Herzegovina
835	1962	Brunei
811	1946	Cambodia
471	1955	Cameroon
344	1991	Croatia
352	1954	Cyprus
315	1967	Czechoslovakia
315	1989	Czechoslovakia
531	1945	Eritrea
366	1945	Estonia
366	1987	Estonia
265	1953	German Democratic Republic

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample
due to states panel coverage (*continued*)

COW code	Year	Country
452	1948	Ghana
404	1963	Guinea-Bissau
750	1946	India
850	1945	Indonesia
501	1952	Kenya
703	1990	Kyrgyzstan
812	1946	Laos
812	1950	Laos
367	1945	Latvia
367	1989	Latvia
368	1945	Lithuania
368	1988	Lithuania
580	1947	Madagascar
553	1958	Malawi
820	1948	Malaysia
600	1953	Morocco
541	1963	Mozambique

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample
due to states panel coverage (*continued*)

COW code	Year	Country
565	1960	Namibia
475	1945	Nigeria
698	1964	Oman
517	1956	Rwanda
517	1961	Rwanda
317	1989	Slovakia
349	1991	Slovenia
713	1947	Taiwan
860	1975	Timor-Leste
616	1952	Tunisia
369	1990	Ukraine
816	1945	Vietnam
679	1948	Yemen
679	1955	Yemen
679	1960	Yemen

Note: N = 48 campaigns. For the reasons of exclusion: see a footnote in the introduction